

SALAAM KALAM

**THE PEOPLE'S PRESIDENT
SHOWED THAT THE POST CAN
BE A PLATFORM FOR INSPIRATION
AND PROGRESSIVE LEADERSHIP.
AN ANALYSIS OF HIS LEGACY AND
THE CRUCIAL LESSONS HE
LEAVES FOR HIS SUCCESSOR.**

■ By Dilip Bobb and Raj Chengappa

We will miss that shambling gait and that ageing-rock-star hairstyle. We will miss those passionate PowerPoint presentations, the obvious delight he displayed in the presence of children and the message he left them with. We will miss that cheeky grin and that almost child-like spontaneity in most things he did or said: his tenure was “beautiful”, the choice of his successor as the next President of the Republic was “fantastic” and the armed forces had “a beautiful mission” to perform. We will miss the humility and Gandhian simplicity, but above all, we will miss what he brought to the highest

office in the land: a sense of purpose and direction, and involvement rarely seen in any previous occupant of the Rashtrapati Bhavan; a clear and intelligent vision for the future and an enduring legacy. More than any previous incumbent, A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, the “people’s President” endeared himself to the public like no one before him, earning a pan-Indian following that would be the envy of most Bollywood stars. He entered the Rashtrapati Bhavan as a surprise consensus candidate, and left it as a folk hero.

On July 25, when he stepped aside to make way for the monochromatic Pratibha Patil, there was a discernible sense of loss and regret. This was a man who did not treat the presidential office like a sinecure, wallowing in a luxury mansion accompanied by friends and family, and served hand and foot by an army of retainers. This was a man who spent five years redefining the office of the President of India, giving advice, “igniting minds” as the title of his book says, throwing open those forbidding doors